UCLA Anderson School of Management

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Anderson School of Business

PRODUCT MANAGEMENT

MGMT 440 | Fall 2026 – 2 Units

Course Syllabus

Revised 09/25/2026

Teaching Team Information

Faculty of Record:

Professor Surbhi Kaul
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Office location: TBD / via Zoom
Office hours: By appointment

Course Assistant:

Hershey (Harshika) Chadha
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Course Meeting Times and Location

Timing: 1:00 PM – 3:50 PM
Class 1: Thursday, October 29, 2026
Class 2: Thursday, November 5, 2026
Class 3: Thursday, November 12, 2026
Class 4: Thursday, November 19, 2026
Class 5: Wednesday, December 3, 2026
Location: Entrepreneurs Hall C301, UCLA Anderson School of Business

Prerequisites/Co-requisites

You do not need a technical background or coding experience to enroll in this course. However, you should have curiosity about how products evolve in an AI-native world and genuine interest in product strategy and execution. This course is designed for MSBA students and professionals interested in or currently working toward a career in product management.

Instructor Biography

Surbhi Kaul is VP of Customer Experience Product Management at Cisco, leading a large organization spanning Cisco IQ (AI-powered network intelligence), services portfolio strategy, AI initiatives, and cross-architecture business management across Data Center, Service Provider, Hyperscaler, Collaboration, Splunk, and Cisco Managed Services.

Over the past two decades, Surbhi has spearheaded visionary product and engineering teams at Fortune 500 companies including Google, YouTube, Netflix, Cisco, Juniper Networks, and HP. Her career trajectory—from networking infrastructure to consumer products to enterprise AI and security—gives her unique perspective on how product management evolves with transformational technology.

Early career highlights include launching the first Networking products at GCP (Google Cloud Platform) and leading YouTube & Google Home initiatives incorporating cutting-edge AI and machine learning. At Netflix, she contributed to platform strategy during the AI-driven personalization

revolution. Currently, Surbhi focuses on how AI is reshaping customer experience, integrating automation, ML-based personalization, and intelligent service delivery across enterprise platforms.

Beyond Cisco, Surbhi is an Adjunct Professor at UCLA Anderson School of Business, a National Board Member of ASEI, a Board Member of the IIT Foundation, and leads the 1,800-member IIT AI/ML Forum. She mentors AI/tech startups and advocates strongly for inclusion and diversity in technology.

Education: B.E. in Engineering from IIT Kanpur, M.S. in Computer Science from Texas A&M University, and General Management Program (GMP) from Harvard Business School. CCIE certified.

Course Description

Catalog Description

This course provides students with a comprehensive understanding of the principles, strategies, and practices involved in building products throughout the product lifecycle in an AI-native era. Students explore product strategy, design and development, market analysis, customer insights, competitive positioning, and go-to-market strategies—with explicit emphasis on how AI and data-driven decision-making transform each aspect of product management. Through theoretical frameworks, case studies, real-world applications, and hands-on exercises, students develop skills necessary to excel as product managers in a dynamic, AI-shaped business environment. The course bridges timeless PM fundamentals with emerging competencies: defining success metrics for AI features, evaluating and integrating LLMs and agentic systems, leveraging AI-powered analytics for customer insights, and making responsible product decisions in an era of rapid technological change.

Expanded Description

Product management is evolving rapidly in the age of AI. This course mirrors that evolution, teaching both timeless PM fundamentals and AI-era skills. While we ground ourselves in proven frameworks for product strategy, design, and execution, we explicitly address how AI is transforming the role: how PMs define success metrics for AI features, how to evaluate and integrate LLMs and agentic systems, how customer insights change when driven by AI analytics, and how data-driven decision-making has become inseparable from product work.

The course examines how mature tech companies (Google, Facebook, Amazon, Cisco, Netflix) build products, with emphasis on how AI is reshaping product lifecycle decisions. We also explore how these concepts apply to startups and how data analytics (including AI-powered analytics) drive informed product decisions. Competitive positioning, go-to-market strategies, pricing models, and customer engagement all benefit from AI insights—and PMs must understand when and how to harness these tools.

A typical 2 hours 50 minutes class consists of 2 hours of instruction (lectures, discussions, activities) and 50 minutes with an industry practitioner or guest expert. We combine academic frameworks with hands-on problem-solving and real-world case studies. By the end of the course, you will understand what a PM does, how PMs collaborate with engineering, design, data science, and go-to-market teams, and how to apply frameworks to develop, launch, iterate, and manage products in an AI-native era.

Course Learning Objectives

At the end of the course, students will be able to:

1. Define the role of a product manager and its relationship to other roles within a product team, including how AI literacy is becoming table stakes.
2. Develop intuition for what makes product managers and products successful in an AI-native era, using frameworks for measuring success, market fit, and competitive positioning.
3. Master market analysis skills—customer segmentation, competitive analysis, AI-driven market insights, and trend forecasting.

4. Understand pricing strategies, revenue models, and financial considerations for products, including monetization of AI-powered features.

5. Develop product launch strategies: positioning, branding, go-to-market planning, and communicating value to customers.

6. Master product lifecycle management: extensions, upgrades, iterations, and end-of-life decisions.

7. Define success metrics and KPIs for AI-driven features and understand how to measure product adoption and impact.

8. Evaluate and integrate AI/ML technologies (LLMs, agents, predictive models) into product roadmaps responsibly.

9. Synthesize course learnings, peer feedback, and practical experience to propose, refine, develop, and test significant improvements to an existing product.

Course Materials & Resources

Required Reading

"Inspired: How to Create Tech Products Customers Love" by Marty Cagan

"The Lean Startup: How Today's Entrepreneurs Use Continuous Innovation to Create Radically Successful Businesses" by Eric Ries

"Thinking, Fast and Slow" by Daniel Kahneman

"The Innovator's Dilemma: When New Technologies Cause Great Firms to Fail" by Clayton M. Christensen

"Crossing the Chasm: Marketing and Selling High-Tech Products to Mainstream Customers" by Geoffrey A. Moore

Recommended Reading (AI & Product Strategy Focus)

"AI-First Companies: How to Compete in the Age of AI" by Ash Fontana

"The Lean AI Product Playbook: Strategies for Product Managers to Develop and Deliver AI Solutions" by Jean-Georges Perrin

"Artificial Intelligence Fundamentals: A Hands-On Approach to Getting Smarter with AI" by Anderson & Bonini

"Machine Learning Design Patterns" by Valliappa Lakshmanan, Sara Robinson, Michael Munn

"The Design of Everyday Things" by Don Norman

"Hooked: How to Build Habit-Forming Products" by Nir Eyal

"Zero to One: Notes on Startups, or How to Build the Future" by Peter Thiel with Blake Masters

"Blue Ocean Strategy: How to Create Uncontested Market Space and Make the Competition Irrelevant" by W. Chan Kim and Renée Mauborgne

Optional Supplementary Materials

Case studies and articles will be posted on the course site Harvard Business Review articles on AI, product strategy, and customer experience Instructor-curated resources on AI applications in product management

Evaluation and Grading

Required Assignments and Weighted Percentages

This course will be graded using the following weighted percentages. Feedback and grades are typically posted within one week of assignment due dates.

Assignments	% of Grade
Quizzes	20%

Product Critique (individual)	20%
Success Metrics & KPIs (individual)	15%
Participation (individual)	15%
Final Presentation (group)	30%
Total	100%

Assignment Descriptions

Quizzes (20%)

Short quizzes following key lectures to assess comprehension of core PM frameworks, customer insight methodologies, and AI integration concepts. Quizzes test both conceptual understanding and application.

Product Critique (20%)

Individual assignment: A 2-page critique using data analytics to answer: "How would I improve [a popular product] if I were the PM?" Examples: Google Maps, ChatGPT, Netflix, Slack. Students gather data on product, users, and market trends; analyze using data-driven techniques; and propose creative, prioritized improvements. Grading focuses on critical thinking, prioritization, and data-backed recommendations.

Success Metrics & KPIs Exercise (15%)

Individual assignment: A 2-page report defining success metrics and KPIs for a product feature launch. Students must articulate business goals, derive sensible metrics, analyze provided data, and make a recommendation to launch or iterate. Grading emphasizes working knowledge of measurement frameworks, metric logic, and data-driven reasoning. Special emphasis on how to measure AI-powered features and user adoption.

Participation (15%)

Individual grade based on contributions to lecture discussion, thoughtful questions during guest speaker sessions, and active engagement. Grading criteria: relevance to discussion, thoughtful analysis (not just opinion), connection to course themes, active listening, and preparedness (especially informed questions for guests). No mobile phones during class.

Final Presentation & Pitch (30%)

Group project (3-4 students): 15-minute pitch to an industry panel on a product improvement or new product innovation. Must include: product strategy and positioning, market analysis and customer insights, clear value proposition, go-to-market strategy, financial analysis, and professional presentation. Groups may iterate on their earlier Product Critique or propose a new idea. This synthesizes all course learnings.

Course Outline

Class 1: Introduction to Product Management in the AI Era

Thursday, October 29, 2026

Key Topics

• Defining the PM role: responsibilities across strategy, execution, and cross-functional leadership • The product journey from discovery through launch: how customer insights drive every step • Jobs to be Done (JTBD) framework: understanding customer motivations, context, and unmet needs • AI as a strategic product lever: where and how AI creates competitive advantage and new customer value • The evolved PM toolkit: how AI literacy, data thinking, and technical fluency are becoming essential • Building intuition: what makes PMs and products successful in an AI-shaped, fast-moving market

In-Class Activities

• Course overview and expectations • Product journey mapping exercise • Customer development discussion • Case study: AI and product strategy across Google, Netflix, Cisco • Guest speaker (TBD)

Pre-Class Reading

"Know Your Customers' Jobs to Be Done" – Clay Christensen "Good Product Manager/Bad Product Manager" – Ben Horowitz Steve Jobs introducing iPhone (2007) HBR: "Jobs to be Done" video

Assignment Due

SUBMIT: Quiz #1 by Nov 1, 11:59 PM PT

Class 2: Product Market Fit, Competitive Landscape & Differentiation

Thursday, November 5, 2026

Key Topics

• Market analysis fundamentals: sizing TAM, SAM, SOM and understanding market dynamics • Customer segmentation: identifying and prioritizing your highest-value personas • Competitive positioning: mapping the competitive landscape and finding your white space • Differentiation strategies: how to stand out in crowded markets, especially with AI competitors • Customer-centric product design: translating insights into features customers actually want • User stories, mocks & prototyping: translating strategy into tangible product definition • Product-market fit signals: how to know when you've hit it (and what to do if you haven't)

In-Class Activities

• Competitive landscape workshop: analyze a real market • Market segmentation exercise: define personas and prioritize segments • Prototyping and user story activity • Discussion: How AI shifts competitive advantage and customer preferences • Guest speaker (TBD)

Pre-Class Reading

"Inspired" – Marty Cagan (Ch 1-3) Apple Product Strategy, Steve Jobs (2011) "Not All Good Products Make Good Businesses" – Des Traynor "Escaping the Build Trap" – Melissa Perri (Part 1)

Assignment Due

SUBMIT: Product Critique by November 8, 11:59 PM PT

Class 3: Data, Metrics & AI in Product Decision-Making

Thursday, November 12, 2026

Key Topics

• Data-driven product management: how to use data to inform every key decision • Defining success metrics and KPIs: choosing the right measures for your business goals • Metrics vs. vanity metrics: the difference between signal and noise • ML/AI in analytics: leveraging AI to uncover customer behavior patterns and predict trends • Measuring AI-powered features: unique challenges in defining success for AI/ML products • Product lifecycle & evolution: using data to decide on improvements, extensions, and sunsets • From insights to action: translating data findings into product roadmap decisions

In-Class Activities

• Metrics definition workshop: set KPIs for a real product scenario • Data analysis exercise: practice deriving insights from messy data • Metrics design debate: determine the right metrics for different product goals • Discussion: Measuring AI impact—accuracy vs. user value vs. business metrics • Guest speaker (TBD)

Pre-Class Reading

"Data Driven Product Management" – HBR "Crossing the Chasm" – Geoffrey Moore (Ch 1-3) "Connecting the Dots: From Vision to Execution" – Deb Liu "The Growth Pyramid Revisited" – Sean Ellis

Assignment Due

SUBMIT: Metrics Exercise by November 15, 11:59 PM PT

Class 4: MVP, Launch & Go-to-Market Strategy

Thursday, November 19, 2026

Key Topics

• Minimum Viable Product (MVP): defining the smallest version that validates your core hypothesis • MVP for AI products: unique considerations when launching with ML/LLM features • Launch strategy & positioning: crafting a compelling narrative around your product • Pricing & monetization: pricing strategies, value models, and unit economics • Go-to-market planning: integrated approach to marketing, sales, and distribution • Sales enablement: tools, training, and messaging for your sales team • Launch playbooks: managing the launch process and measuring success

In-Class Activities

• MVP design workshop: scope a real product launch • Go-to-market strategy planning: build a 90-day launch playbook • Pricing strategy discussion: set pricing for different customer segments • Launch risk assessment: identify and mitigate launch risks • Guest speaker (TBD)

Pre-Class Reading

"Thinking, Fast and Slow" – Kahneman (Ch 1-4) "A Minimum Viable Product Is Not a Product, It's a Process" – Jim Brikman "Hooked" – Nir Eyal (optional) "The Best Story Wins" – Tamsen Webster (optional)

Assignment Due

SUBMIT: Quiz #2 by November 22, 11:59 PM PT

Class 5: Product Evolution, Lifecycle & Final Presentations

Wednesday, December 3, 2026

Key Topics

• Product extensions & versioning: managing product growth across generations and tiers • Managing product portfolios: prioritizing resources across multiple products • End-of-life decisions: when and how to sunset products responsibly • Privacy, security & ethics: building trust through responsible data practices • AI ethics & governance: responsible AI product decisions, bias mitigation, transparency • ESG & sustainability: social responsibility and environmental impact • Ethical decision-making in product: frameworks for navigating complex trade-offs

In-Class Activities

• Portfolio management case study and discussion • Ethics & responsible AI workshop • Sunsets & end-of-life strategy discussion • Group presentations to industry panel (15 min each) • Q&A and feedback session • Course wrap-up & reflections

Pre-Class Reading

"Crossing the Chasm" – Moore (Ch 4-6) Responsible AI frameworks (instructor-provided) Product portfolio and ethics case studies

Assignment Due

SUBMIT: Final Presentation & Written Response by December 3, 11:59 PM PT

Class Policies & Expectations

Participation Expectations

This is a discussion-driven, interactive course. Your engagement is critical. Come prepared—do the pre-class reading, research guest speakers in advance, and ask thoughtful questions. Mobile phones are not permitted during class. Active participation includes listening, building on others' ideas, and contributing to the collective learning experience.

Assignment Submission

All assignments must be submitted via the course site by 11:59 PM PT on the due date. Late submissions may receive reduced credit. Feedback and grades are typically posted within one week of submission.

Intellectual Honesty

All work must be your own. Plagiarism and academic dishonesty have serious consequences. Cite your sources properly. When using AI tools (ChatGPT, Claude, etc.) to assist with research or brainstorming, disclose this and cite the tool. AI should accelerate your thinking, not replace it.

Accessibility & Accommodations

UCLA is committed to creating an accessible learning environment. If you have a disability or require accommodations, please contact the UCLA Disabilities and Computing Program (DCP) early in the term. Discuss accommodations with the instructor.

FAQs

Q: Do I need a technical background or coding experience?

A: No. You do not need to code to succeed. You need curiosity, an open mind, and genuine interest in how products are built and how AI is reshaping product management.

Q: I have PM experience already. Will this class be relevant?

A: Yes. Product management is an evolving field. This course grounds you in proven frameworks while explicitly addressing how AI is transforming the role. You'll gain new perspectives and access to industry-leading practitioners.

Q: I'm an engineer/designer/marketer. Is this class for me?

A: Absolutely. Modern product teams are cross-functional. PMs work with engineers, designers, data scientists, and marketers. Understanding how PMs think will strengthen your collaboration and career prospects.

Q: Will there be recorded lectures?

A: Yes. Lectures will be recorded and made available to enrolled students. However, this is an interactive, discussion-driven course; attending live is strongly encouraged.

Q: Can I use AI tools (ChatGPT, Claude, etc.) for assignments?

A: You may use AI for brainstorming, research, and initial drafting. However, all submitted work must reflect your own thinking and analysis. Disclose any AI tool usage. The goal is for AI to enhance your productivity, not replace critical thinking.

Q: Still unsure if this course is right for me?

A: Read the syllabus, explore the pre-readings, and attend the first class. If you still have questions, reach out to the instructor.